Problem Statement: Implementing technology to encourage people to uptake sustainable habits / help the environment

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1Zgoaa_thfIUouR3hadYgMLitP9zcRxgG9epOH_S-9HM/mobilebasic

GOOGLE SLIDES:
https://docs.google.com/presentation/d/1xRobF0aTnKLbDkz_tO3t8R9rihSevlj-uRRVP3xGgrQ/edit?usp=sharing

Background:

- Alex Laskey: How behavioral science can lower your energy bill | TED Talk
    - In 2013, graduate students from San Marcos, California conducted a behavioral study putting signs up in a neighborhood asking them to turn off their air conditioning to save energy. Some signs advertised saving money, others regarding the environment, and another saying that 77% of neighbors have been turning on their fans instead of air conditioning. It was found that the most successful sign was the one implying that everyone else was doing it.

- The Power of Social Media to Fight Climate Change - ACCEPT (aseanenergy.org)
    - Through social media and the internet, we see that the impact of climate change and weather disasters were amplified. For example, when Typhoon Kammuri hit the Philippines causing massive damage, #Typhoon became one of the top 10 trending topics on Twitter that year. Similarly, Google Searches regarding Climate Change spiked after Typhoon Kammuri, indicating increased awareness and curiosity.

Purpose: To encourage people to uptake more sustainable habits through social interaction. People enjoy sharing when they are doing something good—in this case being environmentally conscious—so an application that enables them to share their completion of daily sustainability challenges will both be enjoyable and foster sustainable, long-term behavior patterns.

Solution Concept: CommuniTree: Building sustainable habits through completing sustainable, daily challenges. In order to form environmentally conscious habits in our users, this application will use social interaction as a primary catalyst. While personal benefits may enable a certain degree of impact, social interaction and healthy competition can be far more effective in building a permanent desire for change (Laskey, 2013). This idea is fundamental to our motivation for developing CommuniTree, which combines this healthy competition with healthy habits.

Product: CommuniTree is a social media platform that encourages users to participate and share photos of their engagement with daily sustainability challenges. Each day, all users are presented with a new challenge, such as “Ride share! Take public transit or carpool to work today” or “Choose to recycle a plastic or paper product.” Users can build up streaks, representing the number of consecutive days that they’ve completed the daily challenges, and

view the streaks of their friends. They can also navigate a map by clicking on their friends' profiles, viewing their most recently submitted photos at the locations they were taken. By encouraging these small, daily acts of environmental sustainability through fun social interaction, CommuniTree seeks to form more fundamental changes in the lifestyles of its users.

Target Audience: Teens and Young Adults

Impact: By making a BeReal-esque product, it makes being sustainable more fun, increasing individual participation and impact to a sustainable future.

Next Steps:

- Add features to see community events taking place in the area. If a user participates in an event, they get a badge of achievement in their profile.
- Add more visuals to indicate a user's progression in the app, such as trees placed on the map that grow depending on their streak

Conclusion: Finding the balance between building a product that spreads awareness and building a product that people will use long term is difficult, but by making "being sustainable" a fun activity to do with friends and family, CommuniTree is an easy way to bring people together and foster long-term, environmentally sustainable habits.

Sources:

Laskey, A. (2013). *How behavioral science can lower your energy bill*. Alex Laskey: How behavioral science can lower your energy bill | TED Talk. Retrieved November 13, 2022, from https://www.ted.com/talks/alex_laskey_how_behavioral_science_can_lower_your_energy_bill

Accept, A. C. E. (2021, January 13). *The power of social media to fight climate change - accept*. ASEAN Climate Change and Energy Project (ACCEPT). Retrieved November 13, 2022, from https://accept.aseanenergy.org/the-power-of-social-media-to-fight-climate-change/